

DELHI A Union minister and a director of a leading medical institute had been at each others' throats for over three years, all for the control of India's premier medical institute, the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS). The acrimonious dispute finally came to an end with Parliament passing a Bill fixing the retiring age limit for AIIMS directors at 65 years.

Two days later, director P. Venugopal was sacked. Before his removal, he approached the Supreme Court claiming that the Bill was "unconstitutional, arbitrary and discriminatory". Venugopal turned 65 last July and was to complete his tenure in July 2008.

The controversial AIIMS Bill was introduced in the Lok Sabha during the monsoon session and it became a law last week after the President's nod. Its passage saw the BJP boycotting the Rajya

Fight to the Finish



POWER GAME: Ramadoss (left) and Venugopal

Sabha in protest against "bulldozing of the legislation by the Government".

The war between Dr Anbumani Ramdoss,

PMK leader and Union minister for health and family welfare, and Dr Venugopal reached new heights last year when the Union Government introduced a policy to reserve

27 per cent seats for OBCs in leading institutions. The proposed policy led to anti-reservation demonstrations at AIIMS. Ramadoss, who is also the ex-officio president of AIIMS, alleged that the protests had the backing of Venugopal and sacked him. But he was reinstated at the interference of the Delhi high court.

Venugopal, a leading cardiac surgeon, was appointed director during the NDA Government's regime. He used his political connections to fight Ramadoss, who installed his home cadre's IPS officer Shailesh Yadav as the deputy director of the premiere institute a few months ago. Ramdoss has now appointed Dr Tirath Das Dogra as the acting director for a month. However, it is unlikely that he will step down till the next hearing of the court case on January 22, 2008.

by Shyamal Yadav

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

With Jayaram Ramesh's tongue being his worst enemy, it is not surprising that last week he was eased out of the Committee for Future Challenges. What is not certain is who was behind his ouster—Sonia Gandhi or Rahul Gandhi?

VOICES



"During the Congress-led UPA Government's rule, inflation has been rising steadily. If at all anything has become cheaper, it is human life."

Rajnath Singh, BJP president

"The delegation from the EU is coming from China, and I do hope that they have filled their bags with counterfeit products as they will not get those in India."

Kamal Nath, Union commerce minister

"The two mainstream parties should view each other only as political rivals as political space for mainstream parties is shrinking and regional parties are gaining clout."

L.K. Advani, Opposition leader

"The 123 Agreement is finished, it's done, it's completed, it just stands to be approved finally by both the governments. I think with goodwill and hard work, it will be."

Nicholas Burns, US under-secretary of state for political affairs

"Taslima Nasreen should apologise, otherwise her existence shall not be tolerated by Indian Muslims and the responsibility of the consequences shall rest upon the Government."

Syed Ahmed Bukhari, chief cleric of Jama Masjid

